MAKING INDIA HOME Sarala Behn (Catherine Mary Heilemann) with her disciples; and Mira (Madeleine Slade) with Gandhi (1936)

of good impulses but thoughtless, to break their most solemn pledges, [to] take your vow.'

"Gandhi was a towering figure," says Guha. "It took a lot of courage to disagree with the most popular, influential and charismatic person of his age." Having abandoned their original nationalities to become Indian, Guha's rebels were never blindly loyal to their adopted country. "If they found faults in Indian society, they spotlighted it and sought to correct it." The century-long span of Guha's book (1893-1984) is, perhaps, enough to make one realise that India's freedom wasn't the only goal of these brave foreigners. They each also wanted an independent India to take along all its citizens as it progressed. Catherine Mary Heilemann (Sarala Behn), for example, didn't just establish a pioneering girls' school in the Kumaon hills at Kausani, she even went on to train activists who led the Chipko Andolan.

While his deft, enjoyable prose makes Guha a treat to read, the real context of his book, one suspects, can be found between his lines. Having released in the 75th year of India's independence, *Rebels...*, of course, brings to the forefront contributions that might have otherwise perished as footnotes, but it also does something more essential—it forces us to consider our notions of loyalty and nationalism. "India has always been an extraordinarily diverse place and has always had long-standing exchanges with other cultures," says Guha. "I think it's a pity that in the present climate, we have begun to feel that we have so much to teach the world but nothing to learn from it." Guha does, however, add that India isn't alone in its jingoism and xenophobia. "If there is a morality tale here, it's also applicable to the Brexiters of the UK, to white supremacists of the States, to countries like Turkey and even China." ■

–Shreevatsa Nevatia

THE STONE TOWER
Ptolemy, the Silk Road and a 2,000-year-old Riddle
by Riaz Dean
PENGUIN RANDOM HOUSE
₹**599, 226** pages



BOOKS

MARKING THE SPOT

RIAZ DEAN BELIEVES HE HAS FOUND THE LOCATION OF THE HISTORIC TOWER THAT STOOD BETWEEN ASIA AND EUROPE

The Silk Road, considered to be the earliest highway in the world, has fascinated scholars ever since the first century scholar Claudius Ptolemy wrote about it. For centuries, caravans trundled along the road, trading in silk, jade, spices, horses and slaves. Because of their travels, two continents discovered each other and the encounter between their cultures and religions changed human history. So important is this route that the present Chinese government has decided to expand trade in an ambitious—and controversial—Belt and Road initiative.

Ptolemy listed thousands of places along the route in his monumental atlas of the ancient world, *Geographia*. A dozen times he mentions a Stone Tower on top of a revered mountain, which marks the midpoint in the route linking Asia and Europe. But Ptolemy was vague in his descriptions of the tower and often wrong in his maps, which, for centuries, misdirected scholars and explorers, including Christopher Columbus. Ptolemy's long-lost work was rediscovered by a monk in the Middle Ages and scholars have since then debated the exact location of the Stone Tower.

Historian-geographer Riaz Dean attempts to solve the 2,000-year-old riddle in *The Stone Tower*. Sifting through dozens of descriptions and relying on modern cartographical tools and NASA photographs, Dean says that identifying the landmark would help in future excavations and understanding of the history of civilisations that existed along the route.

RIAZ DEAN says identifying the tower would help in future excavations and understanding the route's history

The tower was a special place high up in the sacred mountains in a region known as the Roof of the World. It was the gateway into and out of the western regions of China. Dean himself retraced a long section of the Silk Road and published his early findings in a journal article in 2015.

The book is divided into three sections. The first describes the birth of the Silk Road; the second covers key historical events that mark the establishment of the tower as the midpoint in the road. Dean narrates the history and life of two major tribes that ruled the area. The Kushans were middlemen in the trade between the two continents. They were soon replaced by the Sogdians, of Aryan descent, who originated in Persia and now occupy a region covered by Uzbekistan, Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan. The third section—it makes for dense reading—describes how he honed in on the actual location of the Tower. Dean peppers each chapter with an imaginary description of the life of traders over a span of 300 years, bringing alive the caravanserais where the convoys rested and traded before moving on. The rest of the book would suit a scholar or a history buff but the whole is lightened by maps and photographs. ■

–G. Krishnan